suspect," said Shula Mola, the chair of the Israeli Association for Ethiopian Jews. "I can't explain it any other way. It's about their color."

Decades later, many of them continue to live in grim conditions. Just half of Ethiopian high school students passed their matriculation exams in 2013, compared to 63 per cent of the general population, according to Israel's Central Bureau of Statistics. Mola said many Ethiopian teenagers are pushed into vocational programs instead of university. Salaries for Ethiopian families are one-third lower than the national average. "It's not just a gap between the police and the Ethiopian community," said Assefa-Dawit. "When an Ethiopian applies for a job, as impressive as his CV might be, he's not going to be invited for an interview because he has an Ethiopian name."

Racism in Israel is not limited to Ethiopians, of course. Indeed, some of the protesters in Tel Aviv chanted slogans like "we aren't Arabs!" Ahmad Tibi, a Palestinian member of the Knesset, argued that the police were relatively restrained, compared to how they deal with protests within his own community. "Every Arab wishes to be Ethiopian for a few hours," he said.

There is a long history of intra-Jewish discrimination. The first Zionist leaders were Europeans, and they regarded their Arab counterparts as backwards. David Ben-Gurion called them "rabble", a "generation of the desert" that lacked "a trace of Jewish or human education." He warned in 1949 about the prospect of Israelis becoming Arabs. "It is incumbent upon us to struggle against the spirit of the Levant, which corrupts individuals and societies." Abba Eban, the legendary Israeli diplomat, expressed a desire to "infuse them with an Occidental spirit, rather than allow them to drag us into an unnatural Orientalism." Golda Meir wondered if Israel could raise them to "a suitable level of civilization." For decades, there have been suspicions that the children of Mizrahi immigrants (mostly from Yemen) were systematically kidnapped and given to Ashkenazi families. The state appointed three separate commissions to investigate the claims. Their findings were finally declassified in 2016, but they offered few definite answers. Some doctors testified that many of the children had died in hospital, amidst a widespread polio epidemic; other medical staff reported seeing children handed over for adoption, without their parents' consent. (Whatever really happened, the fact that the rumor persisted for half a century speaks volumes about the level of communal distrust.)